

Chapter 6 — New Questions and Ideas

Buddhism, Upanishads, and Jainism

The one-line point: Around 600 BCE, an extraordinary number of people simultaneously started asking "*what is the point of all this ritual?*" Out of that ferment came **Buddhism, Jainism and the Upanishads** — three answers that reshaped Asia. **This is the highest-yield chapter for Prelims and Art & Culture combined.**

← Ch.5 | Index | Next: Ch.7 →

Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Ancient India
Sub-discipline	Religious & Intellectual History (the "Age of Ferment" / Shramana movements)
Period	~600 BCE – 400 BCE (the teachers); influence continues for millennia
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> AND <i>Art & Culture</i> — asked from both angles
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ <i>Indian culture</i> — <i>art forms, literature and architecture</i> : Buddhist stupa art, Jain architecture, Buddhist literature, philosophy
Also feeds	Art & Culture ★ ★ ★ (stupas, caves, sculpture, Buddhist councils, schools), Ethics (GS4) ★ (ahimsa, the Middle Path, Buddhist ethics, Jain values), Indian Society (challenge to caste), IR (Buddhist diplomacy, India's soft power)
Weightage	★ ★ ★ ★ ★ — among the most-asked topics in the entire Ancient India syllabus
Overlaps with	Ch.5 (both teachers came from ganas), Ch.7 (Ashoka's dhamma), Ch.10 (stupas, caves, Ajanta)

 **Ancient India, but read it as Art & Culture.** For Mains, this chapter's real destination is GS1's culture section. For Ethics, the Middle Path and *ahimsa* are quotable. **This is the most cross-cutting chapter in the book.**

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Explain why** so many new ideas emerged simultaneously around 600 BCE (the four social causes).
- ☐ **Narrate** the Buddha's life with correct place-names for each of the four great events.
- ☐ **State** the **Four Noble Truths** and the **Eightfold Path** in order.
- ☐ **Explain** *anicca, anatta, dukkha, tanha, nirvana, karma* and the **Middle Path**.
- ☐ **Describe** the Buddhist **sangha** — its rules, its members, and its proto-democratic procedure.
- ☐ **Distinguish** Hinayana/Theravada from Mahayana, and know where Vajrayana fits.
- ☐ **List** the four **Buddhist Councils** with venue, ruler and outcome.
- ☐ **Name** the Buddhist canon (**Tripitaka**) and its three baskets.

- ☐ **Explain** the core Upanishadic ideas — *atman*, *brahman*, their identity — and name key figures.
- ☐ **Narrate** Mahavira's life and state the **five vows** and **three jewels** of Jainism.
- ☐ **Explain** *anekantavada* and *syadvada*, and the Digambara/Svetambara split.
- ☐ **Compare** Buddhism and Jainism across at least eight dimensions.
- ☐ **Describe** the *ashrama* system and the other schools (Ajivikas, Charvaka).
- ☐ **Assess** why Buddhism declined in India while flourishing abroad.

Start Here: Why Did Everyone Start Questioning at Once?

Something genuinely strange happened around **600 BCE**. Not just in India — across Eurasia:

THE "AXIAL AGE" — roughly 800–200 BCE, worldwide

INDIA	→	Buddha, Mahavira, the Upanishadic thinkers
CHINA	→	Confucius, Lao Tzu
GREECE	→	Socrates, Plato, Pythagoras
PERSIA	→	Zoroaster
ISRAEL	→	The Hebrew prophets

Independently, in different civilisations, people stopped asking "how do I please the gods?" and started asking "how should I LIVE? what is the SELF? what is TRUE?"

But why in India specifically, and why *then*? Four concrete reasons — and they all come straight out of Chapter 5:

Cause	Explanation
1. Ritual had become absurdly expensive	Later Vedic sacrifices (Ashvamedha, Rajasuya) required hundreds of animals and enormous priestly fees. Only kings could afford salvation. Ordinary people were priced out of their own religion
2. A new commercial class had money but no status	The second urbanisation (Ch.5) created wealthy merchants (<i>setthis</i>) and artisans — Vaishyas in the varna order, ranked <i>below</i> priests and warriors no matter how rich they became. Buddhism and Jainism offered them spiritual equality , and they became the great patrons
3. Varna rigidity was resented	Birth-based hierarchy denied Shudras access to Vedic learning and ritual entirely. Both new religions rejected birth as the basis of worth
4. Agricultural change + ahimsa's economic logic ★	Settled agriculture made cattle vital as draught animals . Killing hundreds of cattle in sacrifice was now economically destructive . The doctrine of <i>ahimsa</i> had a material logic behind its moral one

 **That fourth point is the sophisticated one, and it's exactly the kind of causal link Mains rewards.** *Ahimsa* was not only an ethical revelation; it aligned with the economic interests of an agrarian society that needed its bullocks alive. **Ideas succeed when they fit their material conditions.**

 **And note where the teachers came from (Ch.5 payoff):** the Buddha was born into the **Shakya gana**, Mahavira into the **Vajji sangha**. **Both came from republics, not monarchies** — societies already used to debate, dissent and collective decision-making. That's not a coincidence.



The Software Engineer's Analogy

VEDIC RITUALISM AS A LEGACY SYSTEM

- Enormous, complex, and ONLY the priests knew how to operate it
- Ran on a proprietary language (Sanskrit) most users couldn't read
- Licensing fees (dakshina) had grown prohibitive
- Access control by BIRTH – you couldn't even get an account if you were a Shudra

THEN – three responses:

UPANISHADS = REFACTOR FROM WITHIN

Keep the Vedic corpus, but reinterpret it. Ritual is secondary; the real question is the nature of the self.
Backwards-compatible: still inside the tradition.

BUDDHISM = COMPLETE REWRITE, OPEN SOURCE

New codebase. Documentation in the VERNACULAR (Pali/Prakrit) so anyone can read it. NO access control by birth.
Ships with a defined community process (the sangha) that has quorum rules and voting. → Went global.

JAINISM = COMPLETE REWRITE, MAXIMUM RIGOUR

Also new, also vernacular, also no birth barrier – but with far stricter constraints. Harder to adopt, so it stayed smaller – but it NEVER died in India, unlike Buddhism.



The single most consequential design decision in this chapter: the Buddha and Mahavira taught in **Prakrit/Pali** — the languages ordinary people actually spoke — not Sanskrit. **Removing the language barrier removed the priesthood's monopoly.** Vernacular documentation is what made these movements mass movements.

PART A — BUDDHISM

1 The Buddha's Life — Place-Names Matter

THE FOUR GREAT EVENTS – and where each happened

- 1 BIRTH → LUMBINI (Nepal)
c. 563 BCE
Siddhartha Gautama of the SHAKYA gana (Kapilavastu)
Father: Sudhodana
Under a sal tree, in a garden. His mother Mahamaya was travelling to her parents' home.
Marked later by an ASHOKAN PILLAR bearing an inscription – one of the few sites verified by an inscription.
UNESCO World Heritage Site.
↓
THE FOUR SIGHTS — At 29, riding out from the palace, he sees:
an OLD man a SICK man a CORPSE
an ASCETIC (calm amid all this suffering)
→ "MAHABHINISHKRAMANA" – the Great Departure.
He leaves palace, wife (Yashodhara) and son (Rahula) to seek an answer.
↓
SIX YEARS — Extreme asceticism, near-starvation. It fails.
→ He concludes: neither indulgence NOR self-torture works. → THE MIDDLE PATH.
↓
- 2 ENLIGHTENMENT → BODH GAYA (Bihar)
After 49 days of meditation
Under a PEEPAL / BODHI tree, on the banks of the Niranjana river.
→ He becomes "BUDDHA" = THE AWAKENED ONE
Mahabodhi Temple – UNESCO World Heritage.
↓
- 3 FIRST SERMON → SARNATH (near Varanasi, UP)
"DHAMMACHAKKA-PPAVATTANA"
= Turning the Wheel of Dhamma
In the DEER PARK (Isipatana/Rishipattana), to his FIVE former companions.
Site of ASHOKA'S LION CAPITAL – India's NATIONAL EMBLEM (Ch.7 & 10).
↓
- 4 DEATH → KUSHINAGAR (UP)
c. 483 BCE, aged 80
"MAHAPARINIRVANA" – the final passing.
In the Malla territory, between two sal trees.
His relics were divided and enshrined in STUPAS (→ Ch.10).

★ "Lumbini – Bodh Gaya – Sarnath – Kushinagar" is one of the most reliably asked sequences in Indian history. **Learn it as a chant.** Memory hook: "L-B-S-K" → *Born, Enlightened, Preached, Died.*

Other key sites: **Rajgir** (where he often stayed; the First Council), **Shravasti** (Jetavana monastery; many sermons), **Vaishali** (where women were first admitted to the sangha; the Second Council), **Sankasya** (descent from heaven), **Nalanda**.

 The **Eight Great Places (Ashtamahasthanas)** of Buddhism: Lumbini, Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, Kushinagar + Rajgir, Shravasti, Sankasya, Vaishali. These form the modern **Buddhist Circuit** – which is also a live tourism/diplomacy initiative, giving this a current-affairs hook.

2 The Teaching

🌀 The Four Noble Truths (*Ariya Sacchani*) ★★

- | | | |
|---|----------|---|
| 1 | DUKKHA | "There IS suffering."
The world is full of suffering – birth, ageing, sickness, death, separation, unfulfilled desire. |
| 2 | SAMUDAYA | "Suffering has a CAUSE."
The cause is TANHA – craving, thirst, attachment, the endless wanting of more. |
| 3 | NIRODHA | "Suffering CAN END."
Remove the craving and the suffering ceases. This is NIRVANA. |
| 4 | MAGGA | "There is a PATH to end it."
The ASHTANGIKA MARGA – the Eightfold Path. |

🖨️ **This is a diagnostic structure, not a creed.** Problem exists → root cause identified → the problem is solvable → here is the remediation procedure. It reads like a well-written incident report, and that's precisely why the Buddha was called a *physician* of the mind in early texts. **He didn't say "believe me"; he said "test it."**

🌀 The Eightfold Path (*Ashtangika Marga*) ★★

Grouped into three trainings — **learn the grouping, it's asked:**

Group	Steps	Meaning
PRAJNA (Wisdom) 🧠	1. Right View (<i>samma ditthi</i>) 2. Right Intention/Thought (<i>samma sankappa</i>)	Understanding reality as it is; renouncing ill-will and harm
SHILA (Ethical conduct) 🍷	3. Right Speech 4. Right Action 5. Right Livelihood	No lying/harsh speech; no killing, stealing, sexual misconduct; earning without harming others
SAMADHI (Mental discipline) 🧘	6. Right Effort 7. Right Mindfulness (<i>sati</i>) 8. Right Concentration	Cultivating wholesome states; awareness of body and mind; meditative absorption

★ **The "Right Livelihood" step deserves a moment.** The Buddha explicitly ruled out professions causing harm — trading in weapons, in living beings, in meat, in intoxicants, in poison. **That is a 2,500-year-old doctrine of ethical business conduct.** It's a genuinely strong citation for a **GS4 Ethics** answer on corporate responsibility or professional ethics.

⚖️ The Middle Path (*Majjhima Patipada*) ★

Between **self-indulgence** (his palace years) and **self-mortification** (his six years of extreme asceticism). **Neither extreme works.**

The famous image: a *veena* string too loose won't play; too tight, it snaps. **Tune it correctly and it makes music.**

🎯 **This is Buddhism's key differentiator from Jainism**, which embraced severe asceticism. It's also why Buddhism spread more easily — **it was livable.**

Core concepts — know these precisely

Concept	Meaning
Dukkha	Suffering / unsatisfactoriness
Tanha ★	Craving, thirst — the cause of suffering
Anicca (Anitya) ★	Impermanence — everything is in constant flux, nothing lasts
Anatta (Anatman) ★★	No permanent self/soul. ⚠️ THE key doctrinal difference from Hinduism and Jainism, both of which affirm a soul
Nirvana (Nibbana) ★	Literally " blowing out " (of the flame of craving) — liberation from the cycle of rebirth
Karma	Action and its consequences; intention matters, not ritual correctness
Samsara	The cycle of birth, death and rebirth
Pratityasamutpada ★	Dependent origination — everything arises in dependence on causes and conditions; nothing exists independently
Ahimsa	Non-violence (present, but less absolute than in Jainism)

⚠️ **The *anatta* trap.** Buddhism denies a permanent self. Jainism and the Upanishads affirm one (*jiva/atman*). If a Prelims option says "**Buddhism teaches the eternal soul,**" it is false. This distinction is asked.

What the Buddha REJECTED

Rejected	Why
✗ Vedic authority	Truth is found by insight and experience, not scriptural authority
✗ Animal sacrifice	Cruel, and useless for liberation
✗ Elaborate ritual	Ritual doesn't purify; conduct does
✗ Birth-based caste ★	"Not by birth is one a brahmin; by deed one is a brahmin." Anyone could join the sangha
✗ Sanskrit exclusivity	Taught in Pali/Prakrit — the language of ordinary people
✗ Extreme asceticism	The Middle Path instead
✗ Metaphysical speculation	He famously refused to answer questions about whether the universe is eternal — the " unanswered questions " (<i>avyakata</i>). The parable of the poisoned arrow : a man shot with an arrow shouldn't refuse treatment until he knows who fired it

💻 **The poisoned-arrow parable is a plea for pragmatism over premature abstraction.** Fix the production incident; the philosophical architecture debate can wait. It's a genuinely useful line in an Ethics answer about action under uncertainty.

3 The Sangha — A Working Republic

The Buddha founded the **SANGHA** — the order of monks (**bhikkhus**) and, later, nuns (**bhikkhunis**).

Aspect	Detail
Who could join ★	Almost anyone — brahmins, kshatriyas, merchants, and workers/labourers . Caste was irrelevant inside the sangha
Who could NOT (without permission)	Children (parents' consent), slaves (owner's permission), those in debt, those in royal service
Women ★	Admitted after the Buddha's foster-mother Mahaprajapati Gautami persuaded him (with Ananda's intercession) — she became the first bhikkhuni . Other famous nuns: Khema, Dhammadinna, Sanghamitta (Ashoka's daughter)
Life	Simple. Owned only the bare minimum (robes, bowl, razor, needle, water strainer). Lived on alms (<i>bhiksha</i>)
Rules	The Vinaya Pitaka — a detailed code
Vassavasa ★	During the rainy season monks stayed put in one place (to avoid trampling crops and insects). These retreat sites grew into permanent VIHARAS (monasteries)
Bhikkhunis' texts ★	The Therigatha ("Verses of the Elder Nuns") — part of the <i>Sutta Pitaka</i> ; among the world's earliest known collections of women's writing

📁 The sangha's procedure — a real Polity crossover

The sangha's rules include an explicit decision-making procedure:

- Meetings required a **quorum**
- A proposal (**natti**) was formally placed before the assembly
- It was then read out — up to **three times; silence indicated consent**
- Where disagreement persisted, decisions were taken by **VOTE**, using **counting sticks (shalakas)** collected by an officer (**shalaka-gahapaka**)
- Rules existed for committees, censure motions, and expulsion

🎯 **This is genuinely striking, and it earns marks.** The Buddhist sangha operated with **quorum requirements, formal motions, three readings, presumption of consent from silence, and ballot voting** — in the 5th century BCE. Together with the **gana-sanghas (Ch.5)** and the **Chola village assemblies (Ch.9)**, it forms a **three-point indigenous lineage of deliberative procedure**. Deploy this in any GS2 answer on the roots of Indian democracy.

📖 It's a formal consensus protocol with an explicit quorum and a fallback to majority voting on failure to reach unanimity — written down and enforced. Compare it to how you'd specify a distributed agreement algorithm today, and the resemblance is not superficial.

📖 The Buddhist Canon — the Tripitaka ★★

Written in **Pali**. *Tripitaka* = "**Three Baskets**."

Basket	Contents
VINAYA PITAKA ★	Rules and discipline for the sangha
SUTTA PITAKA ★	The Buddha's discourses/sermons . Contains the Dhammapada, Jataka tales, Therigatha and Theragatha , and the Anguttara Nikaya (which lists the 16 mahajanapadas — Ch.5)
ABHIDHAMMA PITAKA ★	Philosophy and psychology — systematic analysis of mind and phenomena

Also know: the **Jatakas** — ~550 stories of the Buddha's previous births. Hugely important because they were **carved onto stupa railings at Sanchi, Bharhut and Amaravati** (→ Ch.10) and give us a vivid picture of

ordinary life. **Milindapanha** — the dialogue between the Indo-Greek king **Menander (Milinda)** and the monk **Nagasena**.

4 Buddhist Councils and Schools

The Four Councils ★★ — a classic matching question

Council	When	Where	Under (Ruler)	Presided by	Outcome
1st	c. 483 BCE (just after the Buddha's death)	Rajagriha	Ajatasattu	Mahakassapa	Compiled the Vinaya (by Upali) and Sutta (by Ananda) Pitakas
2nd	c. 383 BCE	Vaishali	Kalasoka	Sabakami	First major schism — Sthaviravadins vs Mahasanghikas, over monastic rules
3rd	c. 250 BCE	Pataliputra	ASHOKA ★	Moggaliputta Tissa	Finalised the Abhidhamma Pitaka ; purged heretics; sent missionaries abroad (incl. Mahinda to Sri Lanka)
4th	c. 72 CE (1st cent. CE)	Kundalvana, Kashmir	KANISHKA ★	Vasumitra (with Ashvaghosha)	Buddhism formally split into HINAYANA and MAHAYANA ; texts compiled in Sanskrit

🔗 **Hook: "RA-VA-PA-KA"** → **Rajagriha, Vaishali, Pataliputra, Kashmir**. And the rulers: **Ajatasattu, Kalasoka, Ashoka, Kanishka**.

The Schools ★★

	HINAYANA / THERAVADA	MAHAYANA	VAJRAYANA
Meaning	"Lesser vehicle" (a term coined by rivals); Theravada = "Doctrine of the Elders" — the preferred, respectful name	"Greater vehicle"	"Thunderbolt/Diamond vehicle"
Language	Pali	Sanskrit	Sanskrit, Tibetan
Buddha seen as	A great human teacher	A divine being ; many Buddhas	Tantric deities
Idol worship	❌ Originally no images — the Buddha shown by symbols (footprints, empty throne, wheel, bodhi tree, stupa) ★	✅ Yes — Buddha images and Bodhisattvas	✅ Yes, elaborate iconography
Goal	Become an arhat — personal liberation	Become a BODHISATTVA ★ — one who delays their own nirvana to help all beings	Rapid enlightenment through ritual, mantra, tantra
Key Bodhisattvas	—	Avalokiteshvara (compassion), Manjushri (wisdom), Maitreya (future Buddha), Tara	—
Spread to	Sri Lanka, Myanmar, Thailand, Cambodia, Laos	China, Japan, Korea, Vietnam, Central Asia	Tibet, Bhutan, Mongolia, Ladakh
Key patron	Ashoka	Kanishka ★	Later

★ The "aniconic phase" is a favourite Art & Culture question. For roughly the first 400 years, Buddhist art did NOT show the Buddha in human form. He was represented by symbols: an empty throne, a pair of footprints, the Bodhi tree, the wheel (dharmachakra), a stupa, a riderless horse. The first Buddha images appear around the 1st century CE in the Gandhara (Greco-Buddhist) and Mathura schools — which is a Chapter 8/10 topic.

🚩 Why did Buddhism decline in India?

A recurring Mains question. Multi-causal:

1. **Corruption and wealth in monasteries** — the sangha grew rich on royal and merchant donations, drifting from the simplicity that gave it appeal
2. **Loss of royal patronage** after the Guptas, who favoured Brahmanical Hinduism
3. **The revival of Hinduism** — the **Bhakti movement** offered devotional accessibility, and **Shankaracharya's Advaita** absorbed Buddhist philosophical arguments; the Buddha was even absorbed as an **avatar of Vishnu**
4. **Split into sects** — Hinayana/Mahayana/Vajrayana fragmentation weakened coherence; Vajrayana's tantric practices alienated some
5. **Use of Sanskrit** by Mahayana **undid the original vernacular advantage** — the very accessibility that made it a mass movement
6. **Destruction of monastic universities** — **Nalanda, Vikramshila and Odantapuri** were destroyed in the late 12th century (attributed to Bakhtiyar Khalji); since Buddhism was **monastery-centred rather than household-centred**, destroying the monasteries destroyed the institution
7. **No household ritual base** — Hinduism was embedded in birth, marriage and death rites; Buddhism largely was not, so it had shallower social roots

🎯 **Point 7 is the deep one.** Buddhism was institutionally centralised in monasteries; Hinduism was distributed across every household's life-cycle rituals. **Destroy the monasteries and Buddhism loses its substrate; you cannot "destroy" a distributed household practice the same way.** That contrast makes a genuinely strong analytical paragraph.

🌐 **Meanwhile, abroad it flourished** — Sri Lanka, Southeast Asia, China, Japan, Korea, Tibet. Today Buddhism is a pillar of **India's soft power and Buddhist-circuit diplomacy** (a live IR/current-affairs link).

PART B — ॐ THE UPANISHADS

5 Refactoring From Within

Upanishad literally = **upa** (near) + **ni** (down) + **shad** (sit) → "**sitting down near [a teacher]**" — the intimate, secret teaching.

Aspect	Detail
When	Later Vedic period onward, c. 800–500 BCE and later
Position	The last part of the Vedas → hence called VEDANTA ("end of the Veda") ★
Number	Traditionally 108 ; about 10–13 are "principal" (Isha, Kena, Katha, Prashna, Mundaka, Mandukya, Taittiriya, Aitareya, Chandogya, Brihadaranyaka)
Nature	Philosophical dialogues , not rituals. Teacher and student, question and answer
Style	Genuinely searching — the texts <i>argue</i>

The core ideas

Concept	Meaning
ATMAN ★	The individual self/soul
BRAHMAN ★	The universal, ultimate reality
The great insight ★ ★	ATMAN = BRAHMAN. The individual self and universal reality are one and the same
Moksha	Liberation, attained through knowledge (<i>jnana</i>) of this identity — not through ritual
Karma & Samsara	Systematically developed here — action determines rebirth

The great sayings (*Mahavakyas*):

- *Tat tvam asi* — "That thou art" (*Chandogya Upanishad*)
- *Aham brahmasmi* — "I am Brahman" (*Brihadaranyaka*)
- *Prajnanam brahma* — "Consciousness is Brahman" (*Aitareya*)
- ★ *Satyameva Jayate* — "**Truth alone triumphs**" — from the **Mundaka Upanishad**. **This is India's national motto**, inscribed below the Lion Capital on the State Emblem

🎯 *Satyameva Jayate* → **Mundaka Upanishad** is a very commonly asked pairing, and it links History → Polity (State Emblem of India) → Ch.7 (Ashoka's Lion Capital). **Three-way crossover; remember it.**

The people in the Upanishads

Figure	Story
Yajnavalkya ★	The great sage of the <i>Brihadaranyaka</i> ; wins famous philosophical debates at Janaka's court
Gargi Vachaknavi ★ ★	A woman philosopher who publicly challenged Yajnavalkya with relentless questions in open debate. Evidence of women's intellectual participation
Maitreyi ★	Yajnavalkya's wife, who chose the knowledge of immortality over wealth
Satyakama Jabala ★ ★	A boy who did not know his father's name — his mother Jabala told him honestly to say so. The teacher Gautama accepted him as a student precisely because he told the truth , saying only a true brahmin could be so honest
Nachiketa	In the <i>Katha Upanishad</i> , a boy who questions Yama, the god of death , about what lies beyond death
King Janaka of Videha	A king (not a priest) renowned as a philosopher — shows that wisdom was not a priestly monopoly

★ The **Satyakama Jabala story is quietly radical and NCERT highlights it.** A boy of unknown paternity is admitted to study **on the strength of his truthfulness alone**. It's an explicit statement that **character, not birth, determines worth** — the Upanishads questioning the varna order *from inside the tradition*. **Excellent GS4 Ethics material.**

📌 **Note also:** several Upanishadic teachers were **kings (kshatriyas)**, not brahmins — Janaka, Ajatashatru of Kasi, Pravahana Jaivali. The Upanishads record kshatriyas teaching brahmins. That, too, is a challenge to ritual hierarchy from within.

PART C — JAINISM

6 Mahavira and the Jaina Path

The man

Aspect	Detail
Name	Vardhamana , later titled MAHAVIRA ("great hero") and Jina ("conqueror" — of the self) → hence JAINA
Born	c. 599/540 BCE at Kundagrama , near Vaishali ★
Clan	The Jnatrika clan of the VAJJI SANGHA ★ (his mother Trishala was a Licchavi princess; father Siddhartha)
Renunciation	Left home at 30
Austerity	12 years of extreme asceticism, wandering, largely naked, in complete silence
Enlightenment	Attained kevala jnana (omniscience) at age 42, at Jrimbhikagrama on the Rijupalika river
Death	c. 527/468 BCE at PAVA (Pavapuri) , near Rajgir, aged 72 ★
Position	⚠️ The 24th and LAST TIRTHANKARA — NOT the founder ★★

⚠️ **THE most common error about Jainism.** Mahavira **did not found** Jainism — he was the **24th (and last) tirthankara** ("ford-maker," one who builds a crossing over the ocean of rebirth). The **23rd tirthankara, Parshvanatha**, is generally accepted as **historical**, living ~250 years before Mahavira. The **1st tirthankara was Rishabhadeva (Adinath)**. **A Prelims option calling Mahavira the founder is false.**

Parshvanatha's four vows (*chaturyama*) — Mahavira **added the fifth:**

Parshvanatha's four	Mahavira added
1. Ahimsa (non-violence) 2. Satya (truth) 3. Asteya (non-stealing) 4. Aparigraha (non-possession)	5. BRAHMACHARYA (celibacy/chastity) ★

🌀 The Three Jewels (*Triratna*) ★★

1. SAMYAK DARSHANA — Right FAITH / perception
2. SAMYAK JNANA — Right KNOWLEDGE
3. SAMYAK CHARITRA — Right CONDUCT

Together, these lead to liberation (moksha/siddha)

⚠️ **Don't confuse:** Jainism's **Triratna** = Right Faith, Knowledge, Conduct. Buddhism's **Triratna** = **Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha** (the three refuges). **Same word, entirely different content — and this is exactly the kind of thing UPSC exploits.**

🦋 Ahimsa taken to its limit

Jain *ahimsa* is far more absolute than Buddhist:

- Jains believe **everything has a soul (*jiva*)** — not just animals, but **plants, and even earth, water, fire and air** (*sthavara* — one-sensed beings)
- Therefore: strict **vegetarianism**; monks **sweep the path** before walking; **strain water**; wear a **cloth over the mouth (*muhpatti*)** to avoid inhaling insects; avoid eating after dark; avoid root vegetables (uprooting kills the whole plant and the organisms in the soil)
- Agriculture is problematic** (ploughing kills soil organisms) — which is precisely **why Jains historically concentrated in trade and commerce** ★

🎯 **That last point is a superb causal observation for Mains:** a religious doctrine (*ahimsa*) → an occupational constraint (no farming) → an economic concentration (trade, banking, jewellery) → and hence Jain communities' historical prominence in Indian commerce and their role as major temple patrons.
Doctrine shaping economic geography.

🧐 Anekantavada and Syadvada ★★

The intellectual heart of Jainism, and a favourite of examiners.

Doctrine	Meaning
ANEKANTAVADA	"Non-one-sidedness" — reality is complex and has infinite aspects. No single viewpoint captures the whole truth
SYADVADA	"Maybe/conditional predication" — every statement is true only <i>from a particular standpoint</i> . Hence the sevenfold predication (<i>saptabhangi</i>): "in some respect it is," "in some respect it is not," etc.

The classic illustration: the blind men and the elephant.

Six blind men each touch a different part of an elephant:

trunk → "a snake"	ear → "a fan"
leg → "a pillar"	tail → "a rope"
side → "a wall"	tusk → "a spear"

EVERY ONE OF THEM IS PARTLY RIGHT.
EVERY ONE OF THEM IS WRONG TO CLAIM THEY HAVE THE WHOLE TRUTH.

🖥️ **This is genuinely one of the most modern-feeling ideas in ancient philosophy.** *Anekantavada* says truth-claims are **standpoint-relative and partial** — you never have the whole system view, only your observation from one vantage point. Any distributed-systems engineer recognises this immediately: **no node has global state; each has a partial, delayed view; consistency is a claim you must qualify.** Jain logic built an entire formal apparatus (*saptabhangi*) around qualifying assertions with their conditions of validity.

🎯 **It's also outstanding GS4 Ethics material** — intellectual humility, tolerance of other viewpoints, the epistemic basis of pluralism. Gandhi explicitly drew on *anekantavada* for his own approach to truth and religious tolerance. **Cite that link.**

🗿 Digambara and Svetambara ★

The great schism, traditionally traced to a **12-year famine in Magadha** (c. 300 BCE), when **Bhadrabahu** led a group south to **Karnataka (Shravanabelagola)** while **Sthulabhadra** stayed in Magadha.

	DIGAMBARA	SVETAMBARA
Meaning	"Sky-clad" — monks go naked	"White-clad" — monks wear white robes
Region	Predominantly South India (and Bundelkhand)	Predominantly West/North India (Gujarat, Rajasthan)
Women's liberation ★	❌ Believe women cannot attain liberation in a female body (must be reborn male)	✅ Believe women CAN attain liberation
19th Tirthankara Mallinatha	Was male	Was female ★
Canon	Hold the original canon was lost	Accept the Agamas as canonical
Led by	Bhadrabahu's tradition	Sthulabhadra's tradition

★ **The Chandragupta Maurya link:** tradition holds that **Chandragupta Maurya** (Ch.7) became a Jain, abdicated, went south with **Bhadrabahu** to **Shravanabelagola** in Karnataka, and died there by *sallekhana* (ritual fasting to death). Shravanabelagola is also home to the colossal **Gomateshwara/Bahubali statue** (built 981 CE by Chamundaraya) — a major Art & Culture item.

The Jaina canon and spread

- Texts composed in **Prakrit** (specifically **Ardhamagadhi**) — again, the vernacular
- The **Agamas** (Svetambara canon); compiled at councils at **Pataliputra** (c. 300 BCE, under Sthulabhadra) and **Valabhi** (c. 512 CE, under Devardhi Kshamashramana) ★
- Spread to **Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh** — royal patrons included the **Ganga, Rashtrakuta, Chalukya** and **Chandela** dynasties
- **Jainism never died out in India** (unlike Buddhism) — it remains a living tradition

7 The Other Schools and the Ashramas

Other thinkers of the ferment

School	Founder/Key idea
AJIVIKA ★	Makkhali Gosala . Radical determinism/fatalism (<i>niyati</i>) — everything is predetermined; effort changes nothing. Patronised by Ashoka and his grandson Dasharatha (who gave them the Barabar caves ★ — the earliest rock-cut caves in India, Ch.10)
CHARVAKA / LOKAYATA ★	Attributed to Brihaspati . Materialist and atheist — only what is perceived by the senses is real; no soul, no afterlife, no karma. Rejected the Vedas entirely
Ajnana	Sceptics — knowledge of metaphysical matters is impossible
Purana Kassapa	Denied moral causation (<i>akriyavada</i>)
Pakudha Kacchayana	Atomism — reality made of seven eternal elements

🌀 **Charvaka matters more than its size suggests.** It's India's materialist, atheist tradition, and it's the standard citation for the claim that Indian philosophy contained genuine heterodoxy, not only theism. Useful in Essay and in GS1 answers on Indian intellectual diversity.

🏠 The Ashrama System

The Brahmanical response — a life-stage framework that **accommodated renunciation without abandoning social duty**.

#	Ashrama	Stage	Duties
1	BRAHMACHARYA	Student	Celibate study of the Vedas under a guru (<i>gurukula</i>)
2	GRIHASTHA	Householder	Marry, raise a family, earn, perform sacrifices, support the other three ashramas
3	VANAPRASTHA	Forest-dweller	Withdraw gradually from worldly affairs; meditate
4	SANNYASA	Renunciant	Complete renunciation; seek <i>moksha</i>

💡 **What the ashrama system actually *did*, politically:** the shramana movements were pulling people out of society into renunciation, which threatened the social and economic order. The ashrama scheme **channelled that impulse into a scheduled life stage** — renounce, yes, but *after* you've fulfilled your household obligations. **It's an absorption strategy: co-opt the disruptive idea by giving it a sanctioned slot.** Notice also that the system was designed for **upper-varna men** — women and Shudras were largely outside it.

8 ★★☆☆ BUDDHISM vs JAINISM — The Comparison

Memorise this. It is asked directly and repeatedly.

Dimension	BUDDHISM 🌀	JAINISM 🌙
Founder/Key figure	Siddhartha Gautama (Buddha) — the founder	Mahavira — the 24th tirthankara, NOT the founder
Born in	Shakya gana, Lumbini	Jnatrika clan, Vajji sangha, Kundagrama
Language	Pali	Prakrit (Ardhamagadhi)
Soul (<i>atman/jiva</i>) ★★	❌ DENIED — <i>anatta</i> , no permanent self	✅ AFFIRMED — every being, and even matter, has a <i>jiva</i>
God/Creator	Silent/agnostic; no creator god	No creator god; but liberated souls (<i>siddhas</i>) are venerated
Path	Middle Path — moderation	Severe asceticism , including <i>sallekhana</i> (fasting to death)
Ahimsa	Important	Absolute and central — extends to plants, water, air, fire
Ethical code	Four Noble Truths + Eightfold Path	Five vows (Pancha Mahavrata) + Three Jewels
Triratna	Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha	Right Faith, Right Knowledge, Right Conduct
Caste	Rejected as basis of worth	Rejected as basis of worth
Vedas	Rejected	Rejected
Key philosophy	<i>Anicca, anatta, pratityasamutpada</i>	<i>Anekantavada, syadvada</i>
Canon	Tripitaka	Agamas
Major sects	Hinayana/Theravada, Mahayana, Vajrayana	Digambara, Svetambara
Royal patrons	Ashoka, Kanishka, Harsha, Palas	Chandragupta Maurya, Kharavela, Ganga, Rashtrakuta, Chalukya, Chandela
Spread	Across Asia — vast	Stayed within India
Survival in India	❌ Largely declined	✅ Survives as a living tradition

🔴 The one-line discriminator to hold in memory: "Buddhism = no soul, middle path, went global, died at home. Jainism = soul in everything, extreme asceticism, stayed home, survived."

⚡ UPSC FOCUS

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Buddha's four sites ★★ ★	Lumbini (birth), Bodh Gaya (enlightenment), Sarnath (first sermon), Kushinagar (death)
Four Noble Truths ★ ★	Dukkha, Samudaya (tanha), Nirodha, Magga
Eightfold Path grouping ★	Prajna / Shila / Samadhi
Anatta ★ ★	Buddhism denies a permanent soul — the key differentiator
Tripitaka ★ ★	Vinaya (rules), Sutta (sermons), Abhidhamma (philosophy)
Buddhist Councils ★ ★	Rajagriha/Ajatasattu; Vaishali/Kalasoka; Pataliputra/ Ashoka ; Kashmir/ Kanishka
Hinayana vs Mahayana ★ ★	Pali vs Sanskrit; arhat vs bodhisattva ; no images vs images; Ashoka vs Kanishka
Aniconic phase ★	The Buddha shown as symbols (empty throne, footprints, wheel, bodhi tree) for ~400 years
First bhikkhuni	Mahaprajapati Gautami
Therigatha ★	Verses of the elder nuns — early women's writing
Sangha procedure	Quorum, motion (<i>natti</i>), three readings, voting by shalakas
Mahavira ★ ★	24th tirthankara , NOT founder. Born Kundagrama near Vaishali, Jnatrika clan, Vajji sangha. Died at Pava
Parshvanatha ★	23rd tirthankara ; historical; gave four vows — Mahavira added brahmacharya
Five vows ★	Ahimsa, Satya, Asteya, Aparigraha, Brahmacharya
Jain Triratna ★	Right Faith, Knowledge, Conduct (≠ Buddhist Triratna)
Anekantavada / Syadvada ★ ★	Non-one-sidedness / conditional predication
Digambara vs Svetambara ★	Sky-clad/South/women cannot attain liberation vs White-clad/West/women can
Jain councils	Pataliputra (Sthulabhadra) and Valabhi (Devardhi)
Upanishads ★ ★	= Vedanta ; atman = brahman ; <i>Satyameva Jayate</i> from the Mundaka Upanishad
Upanishadic figures ★	Yajnavalkya, Gargi , Maitreyi, Satyakama Jabala , Nachiketa, Janaka
Ajivikas ★	Makkhali Gosala ; determinism ; Barabar caves (Ashoka & Dasharatha)
Charvaka ★	Materialist, atheist; Brihaspati
Four ashramas	Brahmacharya, Grihastha, Vanaprastha, Sannyasa

Traps:

- "Mahavira founded Jainism" → **FALSE**. 24th tirthankara
- "Buddhism affirms an eternal soul" → **FALSE**. *Anatta*
- "The Buddhist and Jain Triratna are the same" → **FALSE**. Completely different
- "Buddha images were made from the beginning" → **FALSE**. Aniconic for ~400 years

- "The Third Buddhist Council was held under Kanishka" → **FALSE**. That's the **Fourth**; the Third was under **Ashoka**
- "Buddhism was more ascetic than Jainism" → **FALSE**. The reverse
- "Both religions accepted Vedic authority" → **FALSE**. Both rejected it (both are *nastika* / heterodox schools)

Mains — this is a GS1 Art & Culture powerhouse

- *"Early Buddhist stupa-art, while depicting folk motifs and narratives, successfully expounds Buddhist ideals."* (UPSC 2016) → Sanchi, Bharhut, Amaravati; Jatakas carved in stone; aniconic symbolism (→ Ch.10)
 - *"Discuss the role of Buddhism and Jainism in the socio-religious transformation of ancient India."*
 - **Ethics (GS4):** the Middle Path; **Right Livelihood** as professional ethics; **anekantavada as intellectual humility and the basis of tolerance** (with the Gandhi link); *ahimsa*
 - **Society:** both religions' challenge to birth-based hierarchy; and honest assessment of how far it actually changed social practice
 - **IR/Soft power:** the Buddhist Circuit, Buddhist diplomacy, India–Southeast Asia cultural ties
-

Term	Meaning
Shramana	A wandering ascetic/renunciant; the movements outside Vedic orthodoxy
Nastika / Astika	Schools rejecting / accepting Vedic authority
Dukkha	Suffering
Tanha	Craving — the cause of suffering
Anicca	Impermanence
Anatta	No permanent self/soul
Nirvana	"Blowing out"; liberation
Pratityasamutpada	Dependent origination
Majjhima Patipada	The Middle Path
Bhikkhu / Bhikkhuni	Buddhist monk / nun
Sangha	The monastic order
Vihara	Monastery
Vassavasa	Rainy-season retreat
Natti	A formal motion in the sangha
Tripitaka	"Three baskets" — the Pali canon
Jataka	Stories of the Buddha's previous births
Therigatha	Verses of the elder nuns
Bodhisattva	One who defers nirvana to help all beings (Mahayana)
Arhat	One who has attained liberation (Theravada)
Stupa	Mound-shaped structure enshrining relics
Tirthankara	"Ford-maker"; a Jain spiritual teacher (24 in all)
Jina	"Conqueror" — root of "Jaina"
Kevala jnana	Omniscience
Jiva	Soul (Jainism) — present in all beings and elements
Anekantavada	Non-one-sidedness of reality
Syadvada	Conditional/qualified predication
Sallekhana	Ritual fasting to death
Muhpatti	Cloth worn over the mouth by Jain monks
Agama	Jain canonical texts
Upanishad	"Sitting near"; philosophical texts = Vedanta
Atman / Brahman	Individual self / universal reality
Moksha	Liberation
Niyati	Predetermination (Ajivika doctrine)
Ashrama	Life stage

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. ~**600 BCE**: expensive ritual, a rich-but-low-status merchant class, rigid varna, and cattle's new agricultural value together produced an explosion of new ideas.
2. **Buddha**: born **Lumbini**, enlightened **Bodhi Gaya**, first sermon **Sarnath**, died **Kushinagar**. Shakyas.
3. **Four Noble Truths**: suffering exists; its cause is **tanha**; it can end; the **Eightfold Path** ends it.
4. **Eightfold Path** groups into **Prajna** (wisdom), **Shila** (conduct), **Samadhi** (mental discipline).
5. **Middle Path** — between indulgence and self-torture. **Anatta** — no permanent soul (the key doctrinal marker).
6. **Sangha**: open to all castes, women admitted (**Mahaprajapati Gautami** first). Ran on quorum, motions, three readings and **voting with shalaks**.
7. **Tripitaka**: Vinaya, Sutta, Abhidhamma. **Jatakas** carved on stupas.
8. **Four Councils**: Rajagriha (Ajatasattu) → Vaishali (Kalasoka) → Pataliputra (**Ashoka**) → Kashmir (**Kanishka**, where Hinayana/Mahayana split formalised).
9. **Hinayana**: Pali, arhat, no images, Sri Lanka/SE Asia. **Mahayana**: Sanskrit, **bodhisattva**, images, China/Japan/Korea. **Vajrayana**: Tibet.
10. **Aniconic phase** — no Buddha images for ~400 years; symbols only.
11. **Upanishads** = **Vedanta**. **Atman** = **Brahman**; liberation by knowledge, not ritual. **Satyameva Jayate** from the **Mundaka Upanishad**. Figures: Yajnavalkya, **Gargi**, Maitreyi, **Satyakama Jabala**.
12. **Mahavira** = **24th tirthankara**, **not founder**. Born Kundagrama (Vajji sangha), died at **Pava**. **Parshvanatha** was the 23rd and historical.
13. **Five vows** (Parshvanatha's four + Mahavira's **brahmacharya**); **Three Jewels** = Right Faith, Knowledge, Conduct.
14. **Ahimsa is absolute** in Jainism — everything has a *jiva*, which is **why Jains avoided agriculture and concentrated in trade**.
15. **Anekantavada** (reality is many-sided) and **syadvada** (all claims are standpoint-relative) — the blind men and the elephant.
16. **Digambara** (sky-clad, South, women cannot attain liberation) vs **Svetambara** (white-clad, West, women can).
17. **Ajivikas** — Makkhali Gosala, determinism, **Barabar caves**. **Charvaka** — materialist and atheist.
18. **Buddhism declined in India** (monastery-centred, lost patronage, lost the vernacular advantage, monasteries destroyed) but **flourished abroad**. **Jainism survived at home**.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Consider the following statements:
 1. Mahavira was the founder of Jainism.
 2. Parshvanatha, the twenty-third tirthankara, prescribed four vows.
 3. Mahavira added brahmacharya as the fifth vow. → *2 and 3 only. Mahavira was the **24th tirthankara**, not the founder.*
2. Which is/are correct about the Buddhist doctrine of *anatta*?
 1. It denies the existence of a permanent self.
 2. It distinguishes Buddhism from both Jainism and the Upanishadic tradition. → *Both.*

3. The Fourth Buddhist Council was held — → *In Kashmir, under Kanishka; Buddhism formally split into Hinayana and Mahayana.*
4. Consider the following statements about the Jaina doctrine of *anekantavada*:
 1. It holds that reality has many aspects and no single viewpoint captures it fully.
 2. It is illustrated by the parable of the blind men and the elephant.
 3. It was formulated by Makkhali Gosala. → *1 and 2 only. Makkhali Gosala founded the **Ajivikas**, whose doctrine was determinism.*
5. "Satyameva Jayate," inscribed on the State Emblem of India, is taken from — → *The Mundaka Upanishad.*
6. Which of the following were excluded from joining the Buddhist sangha without prior permission? → *Children (without parental consent), slaves (without the owner's permission), debtors, and those in royal service.*

Mains style

7. "Early Buddhist stupa-art, while depicting folk motifs and narratives, successfully expounds Buddhist ideals." Elucidate. **(150 words) — UPSC 2016**
8. Examine the socio-economic factors that led to the rise of heterodox sects in the 6th century BCE. **(250 words)**
9. "The Jaina doctrine of *anekantavada* offers a philosophical foundation for tolerance." Discuss its contemporary relevance. **(150 words)**
10. Account for the decline of Buddhism in India despite its flourishing across Asia. **(250 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name the Buddha's four great life events and their locations, in order.
- State the Four Noble Truths and the three groupings of the Eightfold Path.
- What is *anatta*, and why is it the key doctrinal marker of Buddhism?
- Why is it wrong to call Mahavira the founder of Jainism?
- Give five differences between Buddhism and Jainism.
- Explain *anekantavada* with its parable.
- Give four reasons Buddhism declined in India.
- Which council, which ruler? (All four.)